Cunningham, on 15 August 1947, when Cunningham was reappointed the Governor of the province, by the new Pakistani Government.[5]

Divide and Rule

The Maharaja decided to hold elections to the state's assembly in January 1947. The population in the valley was divided in their allegiance between the National Conference and the Muslim Conference. With the National Conference boycotting the elections and the Maharaja's government keeping the remainder of the seats unfilled because of nomination screening, the Muslim Conference won 15 seats and secured the largest elected representation in the assembly. Kak had thus successfully quelled the residual slim chances of goodwill between the National Conference and the Muslim Conference. The quarrel he engineered between Abdullah and the Mirwaiz had gone against the original mandate of unity within the Muslim upsurge against the Maharaja. Glancy's constitutions of 1934 and 1939 had created an electoral system that, while legalising dissent and political activity, only permitted the electoral participation of 10 per cent of the population. Further, this system was vulnerable to extreme manipulation and corruption, especially in the matter of nominations.

The political polarisation in the state was now complete. The National Conference allied with the Congress party and the Muslim Conference allied with the Muslim League. The former had almost total control in the Kashmir Valley while the latter was dominant in the Jammu province, especially in the western districts of Mirpur, Poonch and Muzaffarabad. However, both parties held ambiguous positions on the accession of the state. The National Conference demanded that the common people of Kashmir should decide on accession. The Muslim Conference was generally inclined to support accession to Pakistan but in September 1946, it passed a resolution in favour of an *azad*, or free, Kashmir. This change of stand was engineered by Kak and allowed the Maharaja to hedge his bets till the bitter end. The Hindus, who were mostly confined to the Jammu province, were organised under Rajya Hindu Sabha led by Prem Nath